

Residents express concerns about data centre proposed for Quinte West

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Amid stiff resistance by communities across Canada fighting new data centres from starting up in their cities and towns, a handful of Quinte West residents are speaking out about a proposed data centre for their city. Residents told members of the city's Planning Committee June 18 they are concerned about a data centre creating noise pollution, drawing too much electricity the city needs to grow and the possibility it could at some point draw on city water resources to cool the components. The public meeting was convened to hear comments on an application to change the zoning needed in order for any data centre project to move ahead. An application by TrueNorth Sustainable Infrastructure based in Kamloops, B.C., is requesting a change in Quinte West zoning in order for a data centre to move into the former Saputo plant in an industrial area at 7 Riverside Drive just north of Highway 401 off Glen Miller Road. TrueNorth Sustainable Infrastructure are calling their proposed facility a micro data centre with limited impacts that uses a dry-cooling system instead of water, consumes far less electricity than much larger data centres and exerts minimal noise. Quinte West resident Robert Wharram told members of the committee that he understands a city needs new development to grow but said he was concerned about the proposal and believes "there's a significant opposition." "Since this is air-cooled, most of those fans turbines infrastructure would be outdoors, and potentially create significant noise. Also outside are the back-up generators and the fuel storage associated with them," said Wharram. "This is a big bet. Data centres in general are resource heavy, and they potentially cause issues that are unforeseen. We can look to the United States and locations there that are ahead of us as far as the build out of data centres to see that they cause significant concerns and it's quite likely that those same concerns would be here." "We have to weigh what the benefits are of this and know that whatever we think the potential negatives are, there's probably going to be more that we don't see," Wharram said, adding the proposal does not match up with the city's natural attractions. Quinte resident Theresa Conlin is worried about a new data centre sinking roots in her city. Conlin said, "it's hard for me to believe that this is coming to my community, possibly." "I'm very skeptical of a dry AI centre. Dry cooling would have been happening in the states if that was a really effective measure and I agree with the former speaker that there are unforeseeable impacts on the environment and on our community," Conlin said. "It might be a good idea for some communities. I don't want it in my community." Speaking on behalf of the applicant, Shawn Bouchard said TrueNorth Sustainable Infrastructure is aware of the concerns surrounding data centres, noting the company is choosing industrial areas to place their facilities away from neighbourhoods. The closest homes are near a RONA store as well as to the west about 400 metres on the other side of the Trent River. "Now we have done two noise studies, one which was very good and then there

were some houses that were missed in an area, so we redid it, and they also came out very, very good,” said Bouchard. He said the proposed data centre would not rely on water to cool its data processing equipment negating any taxing of municipal water resources given it will be cooled by dry chillers. Bouchard told the committee: “I agree with the people that using drinking water to cool a data centre is of my opinion a very bad idea.” “In Canada, because of our colder winters, dry cold systems work very, very well. In the United States, they have a problem because a lot of the data centres are being built in very hot climates, and so the dry cooling is not very effective and so they have to use a lot bigger fans if they try to do dry cooling and closed-loop systems and that’s why they tend to try to use water.” “That’s why in some of the areas in the United States, they are affecting the aquifer in a very negative way.” Bouchard said the planned dry, closed-loop system to be used in Quinte West “acts like a radiator, basically like your car and so, that takes that whole issue completely off the table.” He said the new centre is projected to bring “\$8.8 million annually to the general economy through wages, taxation and property taxes.” Mayor Jim Harrison said residential neighbours nearby will be notified step by step of plans within the application acknowledging each new development in the city presents risk. “Anything with this type of business, anything we do, there’s a certain amount of risk. Yes, there is, maybe more so than we ever realized. So, we have to do our due diligence and make sure that we’re making the right decision to the best of our ability,” Harrison said, “and if something comes up, I think staff will certainly get that to us and we’ll continue with the process.” Katie Whitehead, Quinte West area planner, informed the committee: “Dry cooling systems are generally preferred in more modern data centres.” “In terms of the demand for electricity, the owner’s agent has been in communication with Hydro One to discuss the existing electrical grid’s capacity. An email from Hydro One dated April 24, 2026 provided by the agent, Shawn Bouchard indicates that Hydro One has assigned the proposed facility a capacity of 8,000 kW.” “From a land-use compatibility perspective, the subject site appears to be generally well-suited for the proposed use given the industrial nature of the area, and the separation between the nearest residential uses.” However, Whitehead noted, “this zoning bylaw amendment is only the first step in the development process. If this application were to be approved, the next step would be the submission of a Site Plan Control application, in which the technical components of the development would be reviewed in greater detail.” “At this time, the applicant is working with Lower Trent Conservation Authority to determine floodplain elevations and what additional works may need to be done on site to ensure proper flood proofing.” “Staff will provide another report to the Planning Advisory Committee at a later date with a formal recommendation on the application,” she said.